Taliban and Hekmatyar, accepting an Afghan-led reconciliation in 2011, and silently influencing its contours by facilitating meetings between Afghan COIN specialists with their Indian counterparts, India was trying to obviate the possibility of a Taliban takeover on one hand, and keeping its presence robust in Afghanistan's Pashtun-dominated regions on the other.

Conclusion

India went through a steady policy learning curve on the issue of dealing with the Afghan Taliban after 2002. Adopting a dual approach of publicly criticising the Taliban but privately engaging with some factions, India learnt to differentiate between groups who were actually linked to Pakistan and those who, despite their links to Pakistan, sought political independence. This policy learning process, as this chapter detailed, evolved upon an interplay between the three drivers of India's Afghanistan policy, that is, changing Afghan domestic politics, New Delhi's desire to strike a balance between Afghanistan and Pakistan, and evolving international postures towards Afghanistan. The resurgence of the Afghan Taliban after 2003, Karzai's covert dealing with the insurgents (for domestic political reasons), and the various attacks on Indian installations and personnel pushed a partisan-dominated India to reconsider its approach towards the Afghan Taliban. Having invested tremendous financial and political capital in Karzai, it became difficult even for staunch partisans such as Narayanan to avoid the realities of a changing Afghanistan. Already at odds with the conciliators on their outreach to Pakistan, Narayanan refused to entertain serious talks with the Afghan Taliban. On the ground in Afghanistan, however, in their own capacities, Indian intelligence and diplomatic officials had begun engaging with select Afghan Taliban and Hizb-e-Islami figures in the wake of reconnecting with the Pashtuns. Supplementing Karzai's own outreach to the Afghan Taliban, international posture against the Taliban began evolving by 2008 as the idea of reconciliation took roots. Such international changes, which had resonance even in Moscow and Tehran, only increased the value of the conciliators within India's policymaking circuit.